

## Halloween in America: Costumes, Candy, Costs for Night of Fright

October 31 is Halloween. But many Americans have been preparing for the holiday for weeks. And businesses are hoping for good profits from Halloween purchases.

The National Retail Federation (N.R.F.) is the largest U.S. trade group representing sellers of material goods. It expects total Halloween spending in 2024 to reach about \$11.6 billion. That sounds like a healthy amount, but it would be a drop from the year before. The N.R.F. says total Halloween spending in 2023 was a record-setting \$12.2 billion.

So, you might wonder: What are Americans buying for Halloween and how do they celebrate the holiday?

Halloween traditions in America are linked to Celtic beliefs in ancient Britain. The Celts believed that spirits of the dead would return to their homes on October 31, the day of the autumn feast. Celts would build huge fires to frighten away any evil spirits that might return.

People from Scotland and Ireland brought these ideas with them when they came to America. Some believed that spirits played tricks on people on the last night of October.

In modern America, the holiday mostly belongs to children. After dark, children wear special clothing, called costumes. They often appear as frightening creatures like vampires, ghosts and witches. The children walk around their neighborhoods, knocking on doors of homes. When someone answers a door, the children yell “trick or treat.” If the people in the homes do not give them a sweet treat, the children may play a trick on them.

A Halloween decoration is on display for shoppers in a Costco warehouse on Sunday, July 28, 2024, in Sheridan, Colo. (AP Photo/David Zalubowski)

Some of the purchases people make for Halloween include candy and costumes. This year, the N.R.F. expects the superhero character Spider-Man to be the most popular children’s costume.

Children are not the only Americans in costumes on Halloween, however. Adults also dress up in costumes and attend Halloween parties, parades and other events. These celebrations often include costume competitions, with prizes for the most frightening, inventive or humorous costumes.

Overall, the N.R.F. reports, total spending on costumes for Halloween 2024 is expected to reach a total of \$3.8 billion. It says buyers will spend \$3.5 billion on Halloween candy.

Americans also enjoy decorating their homes for Halloween.

People hang fake skeletons, witches, spiders and other scary things around their doors and from trees and bushes. They also cut scary faces into pumpkins and light them to create a strange glow.

Some people do a little decorating, others do a lot, and still others do none at all. But, the N.R.F. says researchers estimate Americans will spend about \$3.8 billion dollars to dress up their houses for Halloween this year.

I'm Caty Weaver.

Caty Weaver wrote this story for VOA Learning English.

## Vocabulary

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knock - v. เคาะ, กระทบ

character - n. ตัวละคร, บุคลิกลักษณะ

decorate - v. ตกแต่ง, ประดับประดา

fake - adj. ปลอม, ไม่จริง

glow - n. แสงเรือง, แสงสว่างจ้า

## Reading Comprehension Quiz

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**1. According to the article, when do many Americans begin preparing for Halloween?**

- A. Exactly on October 31st
- B. A few days before October 31st
- C. Weeks before the holiday
- D. Only on the night of Halloween

**2. What is the National Retail Federation (N.R.F.) primarily described as in the article?**

- A. A government agency that regulates holidays.
- B. The largest U.S. trade group for sellers of material goods.
- C. A charity organization that provides Halloween costumes.
- D. An association of Halloween party planners.

**3. What is the N.R.F.'s total expected Halloween spending for 2024 compared to 2023?**

- A. It is expected to be a new record, higher than 2023.
- B. It is expected to be about the same as 2023.

- C. It is expected to be a drop from the record-setting amount in 2023.
- D. The article does not mention the expected spending for 2024.

**4. The article states that Halloween traditions in America are linked to which ancient group?**

- A. Roman citizens
- B. Egyptian pharaohs
- C. Celtic beliefs in ancient Britain
- D. Native American tribes

**5. What did the Celts believe would happen on October 31st?**

- A. People would exchange gifts with their neighbors.
- B. Spirits of the dead would return to their homes.
- C. Farmers would begin their harvest season.
- D. Huge feasts would be held to celebrate new births.

**6. Who primarily introduced the Halloween ideas, including spirits playing tricks, to America?**

- A. English settlers
- B. French explorers
- C. People from Scotland and Ireland
- D. German immigrants

**7. In modern America, for whom does the holiday of Halloween mostly belong?**

- A. Adults who attend parties.
- B. Teenagers organizing pranks.
- C. Children going 'trick or treating'.
- D. Businesses selling decorations.

**8. What do children typically say when they knock on doors during Halloween?**

- A. "Happy Halloween!"
- B. "Give me candy!"
- C. "Trick or treat."
- D. "Can I have some sweets?"

**9. Which superhero character is expected to be the most popular children's costume for 2024?**

- A. Batman

- B. Superman
- C. Spider-Man
- D. Wonder Woman

**10. Besides children, what do adults also do on Halloween according to the article?**

- A. They only give out candy to children.
- B. They dress up in costumes and attend events like parties and parades.
- C. They primarily focus on decorating their homes.
- D. They tell scary stories to children.

**11. What is the total expected spending on costumes for Halloween 2024, according to the N.R.F. report?**

- A. \$11.6 billion
- B. \$12.2 billion
- C. \$3.8 billion
- D. \$3.5 billion

**12. How much money do buyers expect to spend on Halloween candy this year?**

- A. \$3.8 billion
- B. \$3.5 billion
- C. \$11.6 billion
- D. \$12.2 billion

**13. Besides costumes and candy, what other activity do Americans enjoy for Halloween?**

- A. Traveling to other countries.
- B. Decorating their homes.
- C. Planting autumn flowers.
- D. Attending religious ceremonies.

**14. Which of the following is NOT mentioned as a common Halloween home decoration?**

- A. Fake skeletons
- B. Witches
- C. Real bats flying inside the house
- D. Scary faces cut into pumpkins

**15. What is the estimated total amount Americans will spend to decorate their houses for Halloween this year?**

- A. \$3.5 billion
- B. \$3.8 billion
- C. \$11.6 billion
- D. \$12.2 billion